Recovering Sparse Neural Connectivity from Partial Measurements: A Covariance-Based Approach with Granger-Causality Refinement

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Abstract

Inferring the connectivity of neural circuits from incomplete observations is a fundamental challenge in neuroscience. We present a covariance-based method for recovering the weight matrix of a recurrent neural network from partial measurements across multiple recording sessions, accumulating pairwise covariance estimates from sessions with overlapping neuron subsets. A Granger-causality refinement step enforces biological constraints via projected gradient descent, achieving strong correlation with true connectivity and substantial improvement over chance baselines using partial neuron coverage per session. Through systematic experiments on synthetic networks modeling neural circuits, we characterize a fundamental *control-estimation tradeoff*: stimulation aids identifiability but disrupts intrinsic dynamics, with the optimal level depending on measurement density. We discover that the "incorrect" linear approximation acts as implicit regularization, matching or outperforming the oracle estimator with known nonlinearity at all tested regimes, a concrete instance of James–Stein shrinkage. Error decomposition reveals that correlation from central pattern generators, not model mismatch, is the dominant error bottleneck, identifying intrinsic dynamics modeling as the primary target for further improvement.

1 Introduction

A central goal in systems neuroscience is to map the connectivity of neural circuits from functional measurements [Power et al., 2011]. Small neural circuits, from the lobster stomatogastric ganglion ($\sim$30 neurons; [Marder and Bucher, 2007]) and *C. elegans* (302 neurons; [White et al., 1986, Cook et al., 2019]) to larval zebrafish ($\sim 10^5$ neurons; [Ahrens et al., 2013]) and cortical organoids [Quadrato et al., 2017], span tens to $\sim 10^5$ neurons and serve as tractable model systems for studying circuit function. In each case, simultaneously recording the entire circuit remains difficult. This creates a fundamental inverse problem: given partial, noisy measurements of neural dynamics across multiple sessions, can we recover the full connectivity matrix?

This problem embodies a *control-estimation tradeoff* related to classical notions of persistent excitation in system identification [Ljung, 1998]: stimulating neurons with random perturbations aids connectivity estimation by exciting network modes, but disrupts the intrinsic dynamics that make the circuit biologically relevant. An ideal experimental protocol must balance identifiability against preservation of natural dynamics. Furthermore, real circuits possess intrinsic oscillatory patterns, specifically central pattern generators (CPGs) [Marder and Bucher, 2001], whose detailed structure is unknown to the experimenter. These represent *unmodeled autonomous dynamics* that influence the observed activity.

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We formalize this as a matrix recovery problem from partial observations. Consider a network of N neurons with connectivity matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{N\times N}$, governed by discrete-time recurrent dynamics [Sussillo and Abbott, 2009], where W_{ij} represents the synaptic weight from neuron j to neuron i. In each recording session, we observe a subset of neurons and stimulate a (possibly different) subset. Our key insight is that pairwise covariance statistics can be accumulated across sessions: whenever neurons i and j are simultaneously observed, their covariance contributes to estimating the (i, j) block of W.

Contributions. Our method is general, applying to any network where the same connectivity is measured across multiple partial-observation sessions.

- We derive a covariance-based estimator $\hat{W} = \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t}\Sigma^{-1}_{x_t,x_t}$ for connectivity recovery from partial measurements and provide identifiability conditions.
- We introduce a Granger-causality-inspired [Granger, 1969] refinement via projected gradient descent that enforces Granger non-causality sparsity, complementing structural priors (no autapses, non-negativity) applied uniformly to all estimates.
- We discover an *implicit regularization* effect: the "incorrect" linear approximation yields a better-conditioned estimator than the oracle with known nonlinearity, analogous to James–Stein shrinkage [James and Stein, 1961].
- We systematically characterize the tradeoff between stimulation strength and measurement density, revealing that optimal stimulation depends on the fraction of observed neurons.

2 Problem Formulation

2.1 Dynamical System Model

We model the neural circuit as a discrete-time recurrent dynamical system:

$$x_{t+1} = W\phi(x_t) + b_t \tag{1}$$

where $x_t \in \mathbb{R}^N$ is the neural state, $W \in \mathbb{R}^{N\times N}$ is the connectivity matrix, $\phi : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ is an element-wise nonlinearity, and $b_t \in \mathbb{R}^N$ is the total input comprising both extrinsic stimulation and intrinsic central pattern generator (CPG) drive. This arises from discretizing a continuous-time neural circuit $\tau\, d\mathbf{x}/dt = -\tilde{M}\phi(\mathbf{x}) + \tilde{\mathbf{b}}$ with time constant τ and coupling matrix $\tilde{M}$, yielding $W = I - (\Delta t/\tau)\tilde{M}$.

Modeling priors on network topology and weights. We impose three structural priors on W, each a modeling choice motivated by practical and mathematical considerations:

(i) No autapses: $W_{ii} = 0$ for all i. We hypothesize that self-connections are not a necessary feature of the circuits we model, for two reasons. First, autapses are not reported as distinct structural features in published connectomics reconstructions, including *C. elegans* [White et al., 1986, Cook et al., 2019] and *Drosophila* circuit maps. Second, any self-loop on neuron i can be equivalently modeled by a reciprocating pair $i \to j \to i$ for some neighbor j, making explicit autapses redundant in a strongly connected graph. In our estimation pipeline, this prior is applied as a *known structural constraint*: we zero the diagonal of $\hat{W}$ before any refinement. This is a qualitatively different use of prior knowledge than the "oracle" that knows the nonlinearity ϕ (Section 4); it is an experimenter's belief about circuit architecture, not a biophysical measurement.

(ii) Strong connectivity: We require the digraph to be strongly connected, ensuring that for any node i and any stimulated set $\mathcal{S}$, there exists a directed path from some $s \in \mathcal{S}$ to i. This is a practical requirement for identifiability: in a weakly connected graph, sink components receive no stimulation signal, leaving their covariance rows rank-deficient (see Appendix A.4). Empirically, weakly connected topologies produced dead zones where activity collapsed to zero, while strong connectivity ensured signal reverberation through the entire network.

(iii) Non-negative weights: $W_{ij} \geq 0$. Like the no-autapse prior, this is a modeling belief applied uniformly to *all* estimates (both the raw covariance estimator and the Granger-refined output), not a constraint specific to any refinement step. It is motivated by the measurement modality: EM connectomics, the primary source of ground-truth wiring data, measures synapse *size* (contact area,

vesicle count) but not synapse *sign* (excitatory vs. inhibitory), yielding an inherently unsigned weight matrix. In our formulation, inhibitory effects arise from the *sign of the activity*: a positive weight applied to negative (hyperpolarized) presynaptic activity drives the postsynaptic neuron downward. This is a dual of the standard neuroscience convention (non-negative firing rates with signed weights), and is functionally equivalent for the covariance estimator, which assumes no sign structure on W. By the Perron–Frobenius theorem, non-negative irreducible matrices have a unique maximal real eigenvalue with a positive eigenvector, which simplifies spectral radius control and ensures stable dynamics. The method generalizes to mixed-sign weights (see Section 6).

Nonlinearity. We require the element-wise nonlinearity ϕ to be *1-Lipschitz*: $|\phi'(x)| \leq 1$ for all x. Combined with $\rho(W) \leq 1$, this guarantees contractivity of the autonomous dynamics. Our default is $\phi = \tanh$, which is 1-Lipschitz, bounded, and odd-symmetric ($\tanh(-x) = -\tanh(x)$, so $\tanh(0) = 0$); these additional properties enable exact error analysis via the Stein–Price identity (Section 3). To assess robustness, we test three additional nonlinearities in E5 (Section 4): *identity* ($\phi(x) = x$, 1-Lipschitz but unbounded), *ReLU* ($\phi(x) = \max(0, x)$, 1-Lipschitz but neither odd nor bounded), and *sigmoid* ($\phi(x) = 1/(1 + e^{-x})$, 1-Lipschitz and bounded but not odd, with $\phi(0) = 0.5 \neq 0$). This deliberately includes nonlinearities that violate our default's symmetry and boundedness, testing how gracefully the estimator degrades.

Stability. For stability, we require $\rho(W) \leq 1$, where $\rho(\cdot)$ denotes the spectral radius. Combined with the 1-Lipschitz property of ϕ, this ensures bounded autonomous dynamics ($b_t = 0$): since $\|\phi(x)\| \leq \|x\|$ and $\rho(W) \leq 1$, the map $x \mapsto W\phi(x)$ is non-expansive. The spectral radius is scaled to $\rho(W) \approx 1.0$ (edge of stability), producing marginally stable dynamics that are neither trivially decaying nor divergent. With $\rho(W) \leq 1$ and 1-Lipschitz ϕ satisfying $|\phi(x)| < |x|$ for $x \neq 0$ (as with $\tanh$), the autonomous system ($b_t = 0$) *contracts to the origin*: the network falls silent without input. This motivates the central pattern generator (CPG) component of the input b_t: a subset of neurons possess autonomous oscillatory drive (analogous to cardiac pacemaker cells) that sustains network activity in the absence of external stimulation [Marder and Bucher, 2001]. The input thus decomposes as $b_t = b_t^{\text{stim}} + b_t^{\text{CPG}}$, where b_t^{stim} is extrinsic i.i.d. Gaussian noise (independent of x_t) and $b_t^{\text{CPG}} = \text{cpg}(x_t)$ is state-dependent intrinsic drive with $\text{Cov}(b_t^{\text{CPG}}, x_t) \neq 0$. This decomposition is critical: the extrinsic component satisfies our independence assumption, while the CPG component violates it and dominates the estimation error (Section 6).

CPG identity is hidden from the estimation pipeline. Which neurons possess intrinsic drive is a property of the ground-truth simulation, not available to the observer. In each session, any measured or stimulated node may also be a CPG node; the experimenter does not know. The variance-based CPG detection described in Section 6 is a *post-hoc* analysis, not an oracle input to the estimator. This mirrors the biological reality: a real experimenter typically cannot identify pacemaker neurons *a priori*.

2.2 Observation Model

In session k, we observe a subset $\mathcal{M}_k \subseteq \{1, \ldots, N\}$ of neurons and stimulate a subset $\mathcal{S}_k$. The observed activity is:

$$y_t^{(k)} = P_{\mathcal{M}_k} x_t + \epsilon_t, \qquad \epsilon_t \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_\epsilon^2 I) \tag{2}$$

where $P_{\mathcal{M}_k}$ is a projection onto the observed neurons and ϵ_t is i.i.d. measurement noise. Our experiments test both noiseless ($\sigma_\epsilon = 0$) and noisy ($\sigma_\epsilon > 0$) regimes; the method is robust to moderate noise (Section 6).

2.3 The Estimation Problem

Given K sessions with observations $\{y_t^{(k)}\}_{t=1}^{T_k}$ for $k = 1, \ldots, K$, recover W.

3 Methods

3.1 Covariance-Based Estimator

Under the linear approximation $\phi(x) \approx x$ (valid when $\|x\|$ is small), Eq. (1) simplifies to $x_{t+1} \approx Wx_t + b_t$. Assuming statistical independence between inputs b_t and states x_t (an approximation we

revisit critically in Section 6), the cross-covariance of the *true* states satisfies:

$$\Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t} = W\Sigma_{x_t,x_t} + \underbrace{\Sigma_{b_t,x_t}}_{\approx 0} \tag{3}$$

In the noiseless case ($\sigma_\epsilon = 0$, so $y_t = x_t$), this directly yields the estimator $\hat{W} = \Sigma_{y_{t+1},y_t}\Sigma^{-1}_{y_t,y_t}$. When observation noise is present ($\sigma_\epsilon > 0$), the observed covariances differ from the true state covariances. Since ϵ_t is i.i.d. and independent of x_t:

$$\Sigma_{y_t,y_t} = \Sigma_{x_t,x_t} + \sigma_\epsilon^2 I \tag{4}$$

$$\Sigma_{y_{t+1},y_t} = \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t} \quad \text{(noise at } t{+}1 \text{ independent of } y_t\text{)} \tag{5}$$

The estimator computed from observed data is therefore:

$$\hat{W} = \Sigma_{y_{t+1},y_t}\big(\Sigma_{y_t,y_t}\big)^{-1} = W\Sigma_{x,x}\big(\Sigma_{x,x} + \sigma_\epsilon^2 I\big)^{-1} \tag{6}$$

This is a *ridge-regularized* version of the true W: observation noise shrinks the estimate toward zero, with σ_ϵ^2 playing the role of the ridge parameter. For small noise ($\sigma_\epsilon \ll \sigma_{\min}(\Sigma_{x,x})$), the effect is negligible; for large noise, the estimate is over-regularized.

No-autapse prior. Before any further refinement, we enforce the structural prior $\hat{W}_{ii} = 0$ for all i. This is a case of the experimenter applying a *modeling belief* about the underlying circuit (namely, that autapses are absent), and this belief happens to be correct because we constructed the ground truth this way. The diagonal of the raw estimate $\hat{\Sigma}_{y_{t+1},y_t}\hat{\Sigma}^{-1}_{y_t,y_t}$ is dominated by single-neuron autocorrelation (3–4$\times$ larger than off-diagonal entries), which does not reflect genuine self-connectivity. Zeroing the diagonal removes this artifact and is the single most impactful step in the pipeline: in ablation experiments (E2, Section 4), it accounts for the majority of the improvement over the chance baseline. Note that this prior is qualitatively different from the oracle knowledge tested in E6: it is a structural assumption about circuit architecture, whereas E6 tests knowledge of the neuronal transfer function ϕ, a biophysical property that would require single-cell measurements to determine.

Accumulation across sessions. For each pair (i, j), we compute empirical covariances from the *observed* data y_t only in sessions where both neurons i and j are simultaneously measured. Let $S_{ij}^{(k)} = \mathbf{1}[i \in \mathcal{M}_k \wedge j \in \mathcal{M}_k]$ indicate co-measurement. The accumulated covariance is:

$$\hat{\Sigma}_{ij} = \frac{\sum_{k=1}^{K} S_{ij}^{(k)}\hat{\Sigma}_{ij}^{(k)}}{\sum_{k=1}^{K} S_{ij}^{(k)}} \tag{7}$$

where $\hat{\Sigma}_{ij}^{(k)}$ is the empirical covariance of the observed y_t from session k.

Error analysis. The estimation error decomposes into two terms:

$$\hat{W} - W = \underbrace{W\big[\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} - \Sigma_{x,x}\big]\Sigma^{-1}_{x,x}}_{E_1\text{: model mismatch}} + \underbrace{\Sigma_{b,x}\Sigma^{-1}_{x,x}}_{E_2\text{: input correlation}} \tag{8}$$

For $\phi = \tanh$ and Gaussian states $x \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \Sigma)$, the Stein–Price identity [Price, 1958, Stein, 1981] gives an *exact* characterization. Since $\mathbb{E}[\tanh(x_i)x_j] = \Sigma_{ij}\,\mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)]$, we have:

$$\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} = D\Sigma_{x,x}, \qquad D = \mathrm{diag}\big(\mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)]\big) \tag{9}$$

where $0 < D_{ii} < 1$ for $\sigma_i > 0$. Since $E_1 = W(D - I)\Sigma_{x,x}\Sigma^{-1}_{x,x} = W(D - I)$, the mismatch error simplifies to $\|E_1\|_F = \|W(D - I)\|_F \le \|W\|_F \max_i(1 - \mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)])$. For small state variance, $1 - \mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)] \approx \sigma_i^2$, so the error is $O(\max_i \sigma_i^2)$, substantially tighter than generic Lipschitz bounds. Note that $\|\Sigma^{-1}_{x,x}\|_2$ amplifies both error sources: ill-conditioned covariance (from sparse measurement) degrades recovery even with perfect model knowledge.

3.2 Granger-Causality Refinement

The raw estimator $\hat{W}$ already enforces the structural priors from Section 2: no autapses ($\hat{W}_{ii} = 0$) and non-negativity ($W_{ij} \geq 0$). The Granger refinement adds one additional constraint via projected gradient descent. **Granger non-causality**: $W_{ij} = 0$ where $\Sigma_{x_t,x_t}(i,j) > \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t}(i,j)$, indicating that the lagged covariance does not exceed the contemporaneous covariance. This sparsity pattern is the unique contribution of the Granger step.

The optimization solves:

$$\min_A \|A - \hat{\Sigma}_{x_{t+1},x_t}\|_F^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad A\hat{\Sigma}_{x_t,x_t}^{-1} \in \mathcal{C} \tag{10}$$

where $\mathcal{C}$ is the constraint set. We alternate between gradient steps on A and projection of $W = A\hat{\Sigma}_{x_t,x_t}^{-1}$ onto $\mathcal{C}$.

3.3 Full Pipeline

The complete method is summarized in Algorithm 1 and illustrated in Figure 1.

Algorithm 1 Covariance Accumulation + Granger Refinement

Require: Sessions $\{(y_t^{(k)}, \mathcal{M}_k)\}_{k=1}^K$
Ensure: Estimated connectivity $\hat{W}$

```
Initialize Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t} ← 0, Σ̂_{y_t,y_t} ← 0, C ← 0 {accumulators}
for k = 1, ..., K do
    Compute session covariances from observed data {y_t^(k)}_{t=1}^{T_k}
    S ← 1_{M_k} 1_{M_k}^T {co-measurement mask}
    Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t} += S ⊙ Σ̂^(k)_{y_{t+1},y_t};   Σ̂_{y_t,y_t} += S ⊙ Σ̂^(k)_{y_t,y_t}
    C += S
end for
Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t} ← Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t} ⊘ C;   Σ̂_{y_t,y_t} ← Σ̂_{y_t,y_t} ⊘ C {average}
Ŵ_approx ← Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t} · Σ̂†_{y_t,y_t} {ridge-regularized estimator, Eq. (6)}
diag(Ŵ_approx) ← 0;   Ŵ_approx ← max(Ŵ_approx, 0) {structural priors: no autapses, non-negativity}
Ŵ ← GrangerRefine(Ŵ_approx, Σ̂_{y_t,y_t}, Σ̂_{y_{t+1},y_t}, C) {Granger sparsity, Eq. (10)}
return Ŵ
```

4 Experiments

4.1 Experimental Setup

We generate synthetic networks modeling neural circuits at biologically motivated scales:

- Random directed graphs with non-negative weights and spectral radius $\rho(W) \leq 1$
- Intrinsic dynamics driven by central pattern generators (CPGs) modeled as chaotic reservoir networks
- Extrinsic stimulation as *independent* i.i.d. Gaussian noise applied to each stimulated node at each timestep (the most favorable case for identifiability; correlated or shared stimulation would reduce the rank of the input covariance)

Each node in the network is characterized by three (non-exclusive) Boolean roles: whether it is a *CPG node* (receives autonomous intrinsic drive), a *stimulated node* (receives extrinsic stimulation), and a *measured node* (its activity is recorded). These roles are assigned randomly per session, modeling the experimental reality that different recording sessions observe and stimulate different neuron subsets.

Our experiments systematically vary the parameters in Table 1 while holding others at baseline values ($N = 15$, $T = 1000$, 10 measured neurons, 5 stimulated, 5 CPG nodes, $\sigma = 1.0$, $\phi = \tanh$). Since

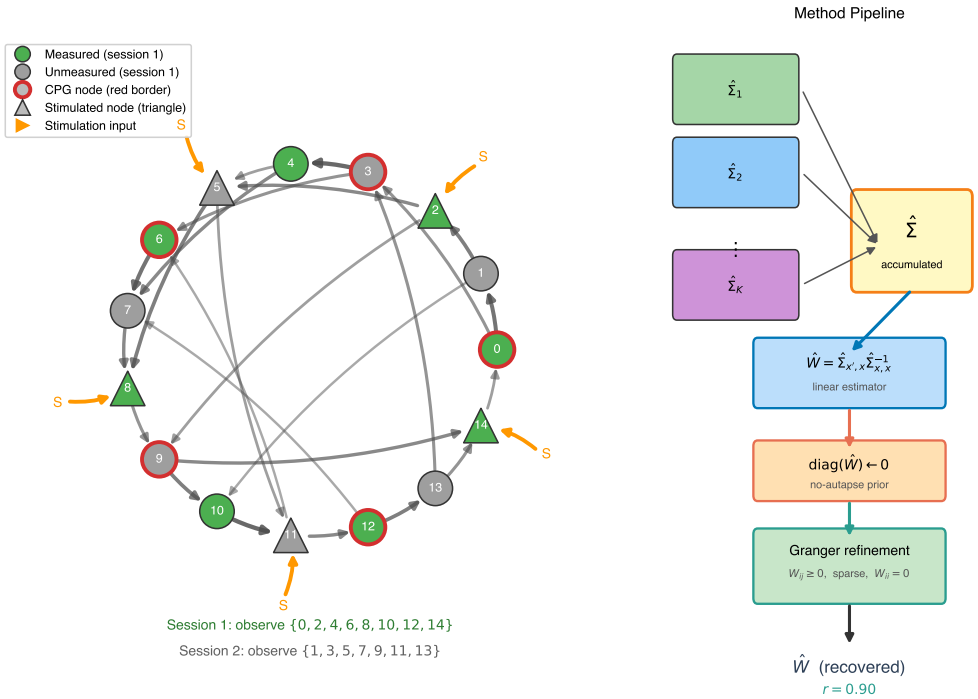

Figure 1: **Problem setup and estimation pipeline. (Left)** A network of $N = 15$ neurons with directed weighted connectivity W. In a given session, a subset of neurons (green) is measured while the rest (gray) are unobserved. Red-bordered nodes are CPG drivers (intrinsic oscillatory input); triangle nodes receive extrinsic stimulation (orange arrows "S"). **(Right)** The method pipeline: each of K sessions yields a partial covariance matrix $\hat{\Sigma}_k$ covering only co-observed neuron pairs. These are accumulated element-wise into $\hat{\Sigma}$, from which W is estimated via least-squares inversion, the diagonal is zeroed (no-autapse prior), and the result is refined by projected gradient descent enforcing Granger non-causality sparsity ($r = 0.90$).

$N = 15$, converting fractions to integer neuron counts introduces discretization: the baseline uses $10/15 \approx 66\%$ measured, $5/15 \approx 33\%$ stimulated and CPGs.

What constitutes an experiment. An *experiment* is a specific fixed combination of the parameters listed above (e.g., $N = 15$, $T = 1000$, 66% measurement, $\sigma = 1.0$, $\phi = \tanh$). One *repetition* draws a single random connectivity matrix W, simulates $K = 50$ recording sessions sharing that W (each with an independent random measurement mask $\mathcal{M}_k$ and stimulation subset $\mathcal{S}_k$), and evaluates recovery. We run 10 repetitions per parameter setting (10 distinct random topologies) to measure variability across circuits, using bootstrap resampling for confidence intervals. The two levels serve distinct purposes: the 50 sessions per topology are necessary for covariance accumulation; the 10 topologies give error bars over the space of possible circuits. We report median Frobenius distance $\|W - \hat{W}\|_F/N$ with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals ($n_{\text{resamples}} = 1000$).

Reference baselines. Recovery error is evaluated against a hierarchy of reference estimates, each incorporating additional knowledge of the ground truth (see E2 ablation, Figure 3H): *Chance*: a dense random non-negative matrix $W_{\text{rand}} \sim U(0,1)^{N\times N}$ (no structural knowledge); *Adjacency*: random $U(0,1)$ weights placed on the true sparsity pattern (knows which edges exist, but not their weights); *Spectral*: an independent draw from the same generative distribution as W (true sparsity pattern, random weights, scaled to the true spectral radius $\rho(W)$); this is the fairest "chance" comparison, representing what an experimenter could achieve by guessing from the prior; *VAR*: per-session vector autoregressive baseline (invert-then-accumulate); *GLM*: per-neuron ridge-regularized linear model baseline ($\alpha = 1$); *Estimate*: our covariance-based method (no oracle knowledge); *Granger*: estimate refined with Granger non-causality zeros. The primary comparison is against the *Spectral* baseline:

improvement from 0.120 to 0.083 (31%), which isolates the contribution of the data-driven estimation beyond what the generative prior alone provides.

VAR and GLM baselines. Two complementary baselines test alternative estimation strategies. The *VAR* baseline fits a single-lag VAR(1) on the observed sub-network per session: $\hat{A}_k = \hat{\Sigma}^{(k)}_{y_{t+1},y_t}[\mathcal{M}_k] \cdot \left(\hat{\Sigma}^{(k)}_{y_t,y_t}[\mathcal{M}_k]\right)^{-1}$, then averages element-wise over co-observed sessions. This "invert-then-accumulate" strategy discards the joint $N \times N$ covariance structure that our global inversion exploits. The *GLM* baseline fits a per-neuron ridge regression (α=1): for each neuron i and session k where i is measured, $w_i^{(k)} = \left(\hat{\Sigma}^{(k)}_{y_t,y_t}[\mathcal{M}_k] + \frac{\alpha}{T}\mathbf{I}\right)^{-1}\hat{\Sigma}^{(k)}_{y_{t+1},y_t}[\mathcal{M}_k, i]$, then averages element-wise. Note that with α=0, the GLM reduces to the VAR row-by-row (both are per-session OLS); the ridge penalty introduces a bias toward zero, analogous to implicit regularization in our estimator but applied locally per session. As shown in Figure 3H, the VAR achieves error 0.136 (worse than even the Spectral prior), and the Ridge-GLM achieves 0.117 (slightly better than Spectral due to the regularization bias, but 26% worse than our estimator at 0.086). Both confirm that pooling before the global inversion is the critical design choice.

Table 1: Experimental design: each experiment varies one or two parameters while holding others at baseline.

Exp	Parameter swept	Values	Question
E1	Network size N, duration T	$N \in \{15, 159, 300\}$, $T \in \{100, 350, 1000\}$	How does recovery scale?
E2	Method ablation	Chance → VAR → GLM → Est → Granger	What does each step add?
E3	Stim gain × measurement	$\sigma \in [0, 2]$, meas $\in \{33, 66, 100\%\}$	Is there a stim-measurement interaction?
E4	Measurement fraction	33–100%	How much observation is needed?
E5	Nonlinearity ϕ	tanh, ReLU, identity, sigmoid	How robust to model mismatch?
E6	Oracle vs. approximation	$\sigma \in [0, 5]$	Does the oracle ever win?
E7	Stimulation fraction	$\{0\%, 33\%, 66\%\}$ of N=30	How many neurons to stimulate?

The subsections below present experiments in order (E1–E7): baseline scaling, Granger ablation, stimulation tradeoff, measurement density, nonlinearity robustness, oracle comparison, and stimulation coverage.

4.2 Baseline Recovery (E1)

Table 2 shows recovery error across network sizes $N \in \{15, 159, 300\}$ and recording durations $T \in \{100, 350, 1000\}$ with 66% measurement. The covariance estimator (with structural priors: no autapses, non-negativity) consistently outperforms the chance baseline. For N=15, recovery saturates early: T=350 already achieves near-minimal error (0.082), with no further improvement at T=1000 (0.083). For larger networks ($N \geq 159$), recovery is poor at T=100 due to covariance ill-conditioning, but improves dramatically at T=350 and beyond. The best overall result is N=300, T=1000 (error 0.014, 97.5% improvement over chance), demonstrating that larger networks with sufficient recording time enable better recovery (Figure 2).

4.3 Granger Refinement (E2)

We evaluate the Granger-causality refinement step on $N = 15$ networks with $T = 1000$, 66% measurement, and 10 random topologies. After enforcing the no-autapse prior ($W_{ii} = 0$) and non-negativity ($W_{ij} \geq 0$) on the raw estimate, the Granger refinement further reduces error by an additional $\sim 4\%$ through its non-causality sparsity pattern.

The raw estimate is dense (nearly all off-diagonal entries positive), yielding high recall (median 0.97) but low precision (median 0.30). The Granger refinement improves precision to 0.40 while maintaining recall at 0.97, eliminating spurious edges without sacrificing true connectivity. The

Table 2: Median Granger-refined recovery error (Frobenius / N) across network sizes and durations (66% measurement, 10 topologies, 50 sessions each). Bold indicates the best result per N. Chance baseline ranges from 0.555 (N=15) to 0.576 (N=300). For N=15, error saturates by T=350; for $N \geq 159$, T=100 yields poor recovery due to covariance ill-conditioning, but $T \geq 350$ gives excellent results. Best overall: N=300, T=1000 (0.014, 97.5% improvement over chance).

N	T=100	T=350	T=1000
15	0.086	**0.082**	0.083
159	0.167	0.022	**0.019**
300	0.130	0.018	**0.014**

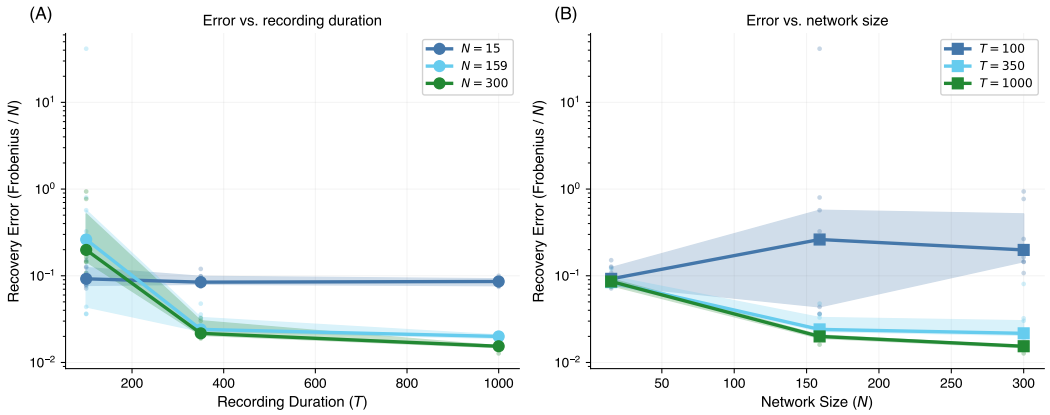

Figure 2: **Scaling properties of the covariance estimator. (Left)** Median recovery error (Frobenius distance / N) vs. recording duration T for three network sizes ($N \in \{15, 159, 300\}$) with 66% measurement. Shaded regions show 95% bootstrap confidence intervals over 10 random topologies (50 sessions each). For N=15, error saturates by T=350; for $N \geq 159$, covariance ill-conditioning at T=100 gives way to excellent recovery at $T \geq 350$. Best results: N=300 (0.014) and N=159 (0.019) at T=1000. **(Right)** Error vs. network size N at fixed recording durations $T \in \{100, 350, 1000\}$.

estimator achieves a 31% improvement over an independent draw from the same generative prior (0.083 vs. 0.120), demonstrating that the covariance accumulation framework extracts genuine connectivity information beyond what structural knowledge alone provides. The constraint that $W_{ij} = 0$ where $\Sigma_{x_t,x_t}(i,j) > \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t}(i,j)$ effectively identifies Granger-non-causal pairs (Figure 3).

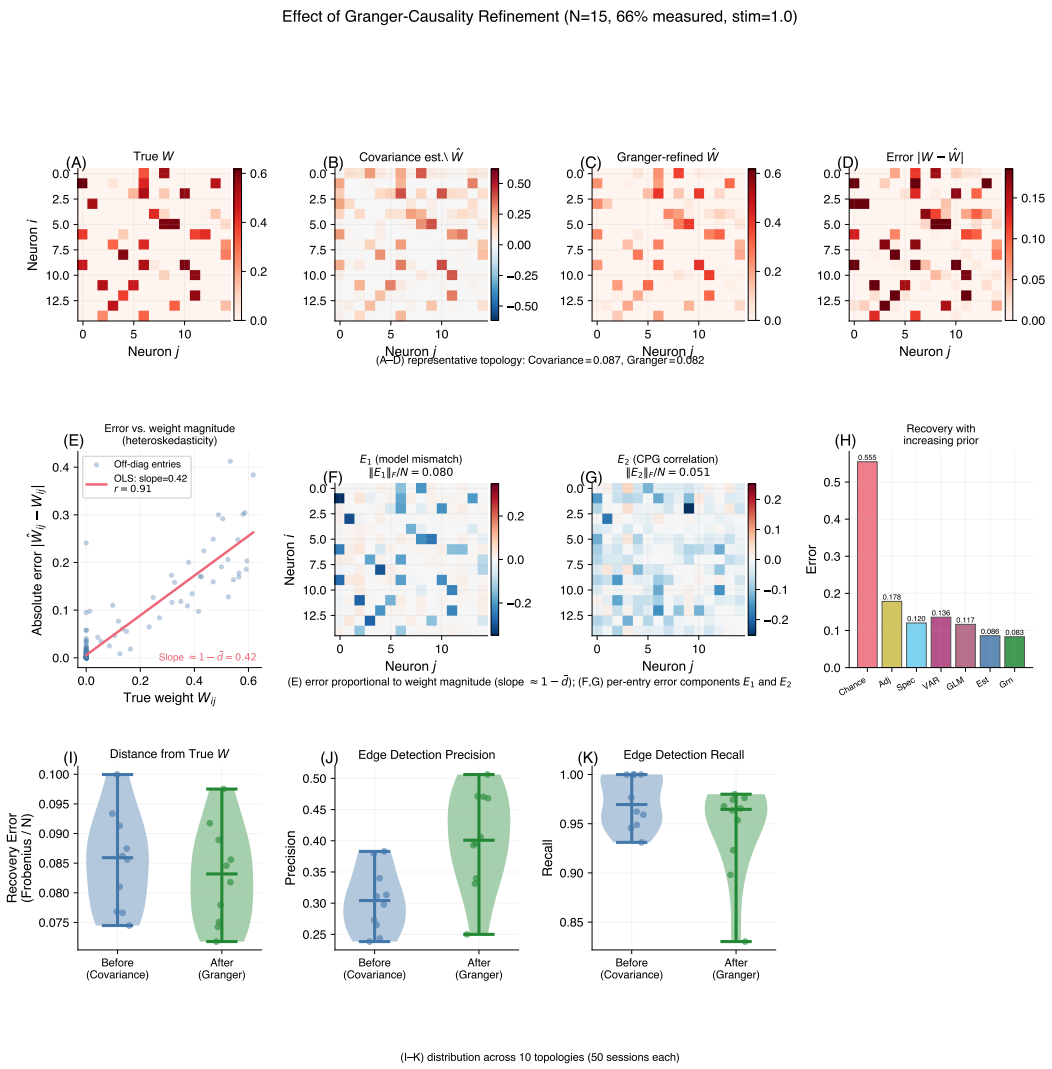

Figure 3: **Effect of Granger-causality refinement and error structure** ($N = 15$, 66% measured, $\sigma = 1.0$). **(A–D)** Weight matrix heatmaps from a representative topology: (A) true W, (B) raw covariance estimate $\hat{W}$, (C) Granger-refined $\hat{W}$, (D) absolute error $|W - \hat{W}|$. **(E)** Error-weight scatter: each off-diagonal entry's absolute error $|\hat{W}_{ij} - W_{ij}|$ vs. true weight W_{ij}. The positive correlation ($r \approx 0.91$, OLS slope $\approx 1 - \bar{d}$) reflects the heteroskedastic structure of $E_1 = W(D - I)$: the estimator systematically shrinks larger weights more (see Appendix A.8). **(F)** Per-entry E_1 (model mismatch) and **(G)** E_2 (CPG correlation) heatmaps for the same topology; E_2 is $\sim 2.8\times$ larger in Frobenius norm. **(H)** Ablation: Chance $\rightarrow$ Adj $\rightarrow$ Spec $\rightarrow$ VAR $\rightarrow$ GLM $\rightarrow$ Est $\rightarrow$ Grn. The VAR (per-session OLS, 0.136) is worse than even the oracle Spectral prior (0.120); the Ridge-GLM (per-session ℓ_2-regularized, 0.117) is slightly better, yet both are far worse than our accumulate-then-invert estimate (0.086, 31% over Spec). Granger refines to 0.083. **(I–K)** Violin plots over 10 topologies: Frobenius error (I), edge precision (J, $0.30 \rightarrow 0.40$), edge recall (K, maintained at 0.97).

4.4 Stimulation-Dynamics Tradeoff (E3)

We examine the interaction between stimulation gain σ and measurement fraction for $N = 15$, $T = 1000$. The results reveal a fundamental *interaction effect*: the optimal stimulation level depends critically on measurement density.

At low measurement (33%), recovery error is relatively insensitive to stimulation level because partial observation implicitly regularizes $\Sigma_{x,x}$. At full measurement (100%), zero stimulation yields substantially degraded recovery, while moderate stimulation ($\sigma \approx 0.5$) yields the best performance. This occurs because CPG-driven dynamics alone do not excite all network modes; without stimulation, $\Sigma_{x,x}$ becomes ill-conditioned. A small amount of stochastic input breaks the CPG autocorrelation structure and ensures persistent excitation. However, beyond $\sigma \approx 1$, recovery begins to degrade as noise dominates the signal (Figure 4).

This confirms the control-estimation tradeoff: experimentalists must balance stimulation strength against signal quality, with the optimal level depending on how many neurons are simultaneously observed.

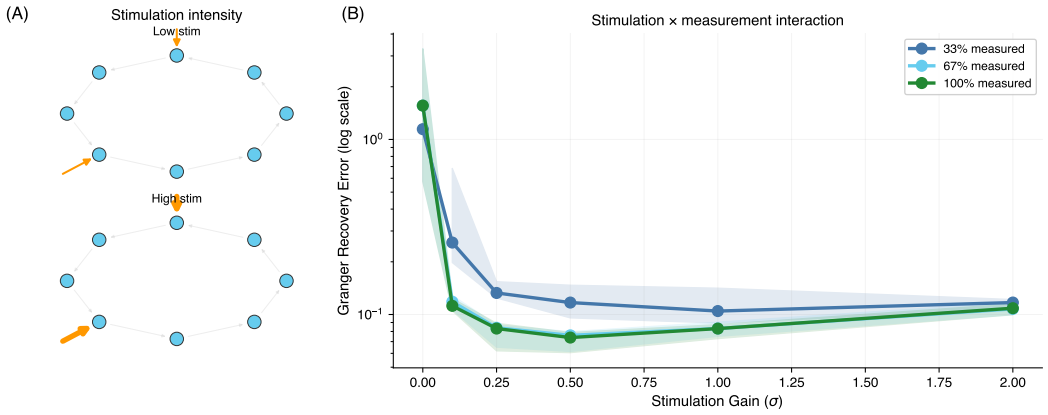

Figure 4: **Stimulation-dynamics tradeoff** reveals a critical interaction between stimulation and measurement density ($N = 15$, $T = 1000$, 10 topologies $\times$ 50 instances). **(A)** Schematic: extrinsic Gaussian stimulation of varying intensity applied to stimulated nodes. **(B)** Recovery error vs. stimulation gain σ for three measurement fractions (33%, 66%, 100%; 5, 10, 15 of N=15 neurons). At low measurement, the effect is mild. At full measurement, zero stimulation yields substantially degraded recovery because CPG dynamics alone leave $\Sigma_{x,x}$ ill-conditioned, while moderate stimulation ($\sigma \approx 0.5$) yields the best recovery. This confirms the control-estimation tradeoff: stimulation is necessary for identifiability but excessive noise degrades the covariance structure.

4.5 Measurement Sparsity (E4)

We vary the fraction of neurons observed per session from 33% to 100% for $N = 15$, $T = 1000$. Full observability (100%) yields error of 0.083 compared to 0.105 at 33% measurement (Granger-refined), confirming that measurement sparsity is a significant challenge. At 33% measurement, the raw estimate (0.110) is modestly improved by the Granger refinement to 0.105. The improvement plateaus above $\sim 50\%$ measurement fraction (Figure 5).

4.6 Nonlinearity Robustness (E5)

We test four nonlinearities at $N = 15$ with 66% measurement and $\sigma = 1.0$. $\tanh$ yields the *best* recovery (Granger error 0.083), while identity and ReLU (for which the linear approximation is exact) perform worse (error ~ 0.17). This occurs because $\tanh$ *bounds* the state values, improving $\kappa(\Sigma_{x,x})$, while unbounded nonlinearities allow state drift, severely degrading the conditioning of $\Sigma_{x,x}$. Sigmoid achieves intermediate error (0.132): its boundedness helps conditioning relative to identity and ReLU, but its non-zero mean ($\phi(0) = 0.5$) biases the covariance estimate. The Granger refinement is beneficial across all nonlinearities (Figure 6).

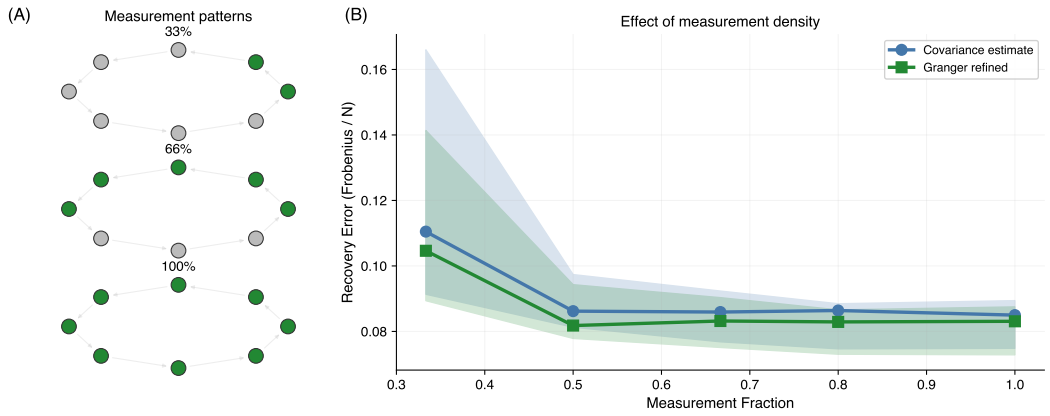

Figure 5: **Effect of measurement density on connectivity recovery** for $N = 15$, $T = 1000$. **(Left)** Schematic: three example measurement patterns at 33%, 66%, and 100% neuron observability (green = measured, gray = unobserved). **(Right)** Median recovery error vs. measurement fraction for the raw covariance estimator (blue) and Granger-refined estimator (green), with 95% bootstrap CI (shaded). Full observability (100%) yields error 0.083; at 33% the Granger-refined estimate (0.105) modestly improves on the raw estimate (0.110). 10 topologies $\times$ 50 sessions per condition.

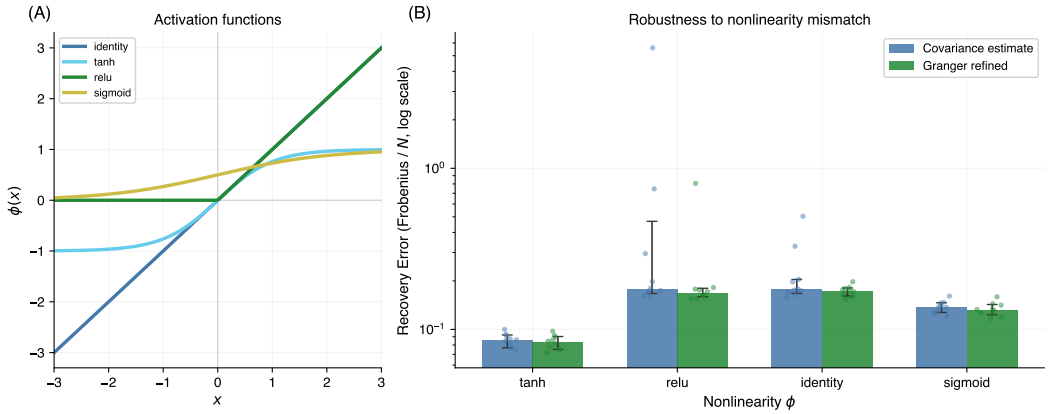

Figure 6: **Robustness to nonlinearity mismatch** for $N = 15$, $T = 1000$, 66% measured. **(Left)** The four activation functions tested. **(Right)** Median recovery error (log scale) for the raw estimator (blue) and Granger-refined (green) with bootstrap error bars. Counterintuitively, $\tanh$ yields the *best* recovery (0.083) because it bounds state values, improving $\kappa(\Sigma_{x,x})$. Unbounded nonlinearities (identity, ReLU) allow state drift that worsens conditioning. Dots show individual topologies ($n = 10$).

4.7 Oracle vs. Approximation (E6)

A central theoretical prediction of our framework (Section A.3) is that the "incorrect" linear approximation $\hat{W} = \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t}\Sigma^{-1}_{x_t,x_t}$ can outperform the oracle estimator $\hat{W}_{\text{oracle}} = \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x}\Sigma^{-1}_{\phi(x),x}$ that uses the true nonlinearity ϕ. We test this by comparing both estimators across stimulation intensities $\sigma \in \{0, 0.1, 0.25, 0.5, 1, 2, 5\}$ for $N = 15$, $T = 1000$ with $\tanh$ nonlinearity, 66% measurement, and 10 topologies.

The approximation outperforms or matches the oracle at every tested stimulation level (Figure 7). The oracle penalty is largest at low stimulation ($\sim 2.7\times$ at $\sigma = 0$, $\sim 1.7\times$ at $\sigma = 0.25$–0.5) and narrows to 1.5–1.6$\times$ for $\sigma \geq 1$. No crossover point exists: the conditioning penalty from inverting $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}$ consistently exceeds the bias reduction from using the correct nonlinearity. This confirms that the linear approximation provides implicit regularization analogous to ridge regression (see Discussion, Section 6, and Appendix A.3 for the bias-variance analysis).

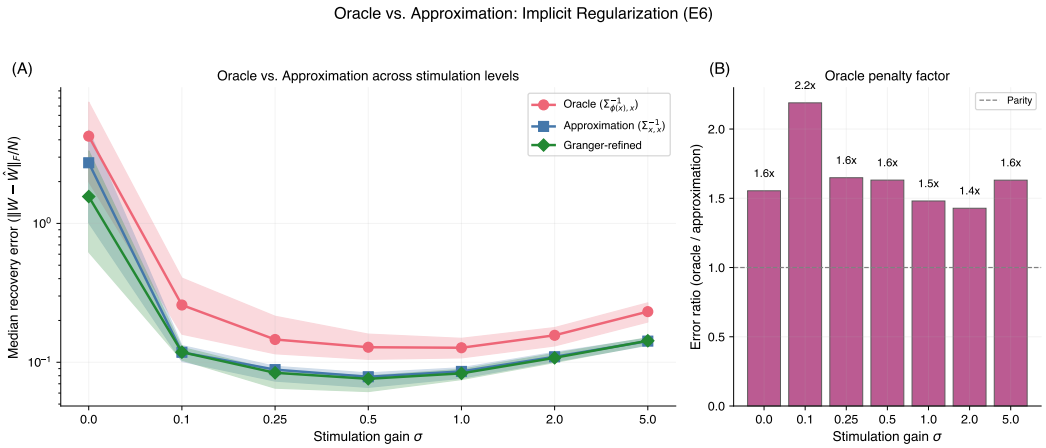

Figure 7: **Oracle vs. approximation comparison** across stimulation intensities ($N = 15$, $T = 1000$, 66% measured, $\tanh$, 10 topologies $\times$ 50 instances). **(A)** Median recovery error (log scale) for the oracle estimator using the true nonlinearity (red), the linear approximation (blue), and the Granger-refined approximation (green). Shaded: 95% bootstrap CI. Dots: individual topologies. The approximation matches or outperforms the oracle at every σ, with the largest gap at zero stimulation ($\sim 2.7\times$). **(B)** Oracle penalty factor (ratio of oracle to approximation error). The oracle never achieves lower error than the approximation, confirming the implicit regularization effect predicted by the bias-variance analysis (Appendix A.3).

4.8 Stimulation Coverage (E7)

Experiments E3 and E7 together characterize two orthogonal axes of stimulation design. E3 (Section 4) held stimulation *fraction* fixed at 33% and varied stimulation *intensity* (gain σ). E7 holds gain fixed at $\sigma = 1.0$ and varies the *fraction* of neurons receiving stimulation.

These axes are mechanistically distinct: gain controls the *magnitude* of each neuron's input covariance, while fraction controls the *rank* of the aggregate stimulation covariance $\Sigma_{b^{\text{stim}},b^{\text{stim}}}$. With n_s stimulated neurons receiving independent i.i.d. noise, the stimulation covariance has rank exactly n_s. When $n_s = 0$, the rank is zero: all input directions in state space depend entirely on the CPG, leaving $\Sigma_{x,x}$ ill-conditioned and the estimator unreliable. Targeting more neurons raises the rank, injecting independent excitation into more directions of state space and improving the conditioning of $\Sigma_{x,x}$. In practice, stimulation fraction is controlled by the number of neurons expressing a light-sensitive opsin in an optogenetic experiment.

We compare three conditions: no stimulation (0%), moderate coverage (33%, $n_s = 10$ of $N = 30$), and broader coverage (66%, $n_s = 20$), at fixed $\sigma = 1.0$ and 66% measurement. With zero stimulation, recovery is substantially degraded (error ≈ 0.83), as the covariance matrix $\Sigma_{x,x}$ has near-zero rank in the stimulation directions. At 33% coverage, error drops dramatically (to ≈ 0.05), matching baseline performance. At 66% coverage, performance is unchanged from 33%, confirming that the benefit saturates quickly (Figure 8).

5 Related Work

Neural connectivity inference. Inferring functional connectivity from neural recordings is a longstanding challenge. Modern calcium imaging enables simultaneous recording of hundreds of neurons in neural circuits [Kato et al., 2015, Yemini et al., 2021], but full coverage in a single session remains difficult. Generalized linear models (GLMs) [Pillow et al., 2008] provide a principled regression-based framework for inferring directed connectivity, though they assume all relevant neurons are observed. Transfer entropy [Schreiber, 2000] offers a model-free alternative that captures nonlinear interactions, but is sensitive to unobserved confounders. Our covariance-based approach is complementary: it explicitly handles partial observations by accumulating statistics across sessions.

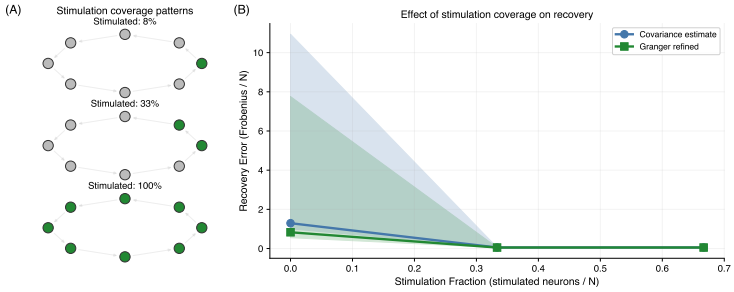

Figure 8: **Effect of stimulation coverage** on connectivity recovery ($N = 30$, $T = 1000$, 66% measured, $\sigma = 1.0$). Three conditions: no stimulation (0%, pure CPG dynamics), moderate coverage (33%, n_s=10), and broader coverage (66%, n_s=20). Zero stimulation yields substantially degraded recovery (error ≈0.83) because $\Sigma_{x,x}$ has zero rank in the stimulation directions; 33% coverage drops error to ≈0.05, matching baseline performance; 66% shows no further improvement, confirming rapid saturation. Shaded: 95% bootstrap CI. Dots: individual topologies (n=10). Stimulation fraction controls the *rank* of the input covariance, independently of stimulation intensity (E3).

Granger causality in neuroscience. Granger causality [Granger, 1969] quantifies whether the past of one time series improves prediction of another. Seth et al. [2015] review its application to neural data, noting challenges with nonlinear dynamics and confounding latent variables. Our Granger-inspired refinement uses a simpler criterion, comparing contemporaneous and lagged covariances, rather than full autoregressive modeling.

Compressed sensing and sparse recovery. Compressed sensing methods have been applied to reconstruct synaptic connections from subsampled neural recordings [Candès et al., 2006]. Brunton et al. [2016] applied sparse identification to discover governing equations of dynamical systems. Our approach differs in that we recover a full matrix rather than a sparse vector, and leverage temporal covariance structure rather than random projections.

Matrix completion. Matrix completion (recovering a matrix from a subset of its entries) has been studied extensively under low-rank assumptions [Candès and Recht, 2009]. Nuclear norm minimization can recover a rank-r matrix of size $N \times N$ from $O(rN \log^2 N)$ uniformly sampled entries. Our problem shares the high-level structure (recover a matrix from partial information) but differs in two key respects: the connectivity matrix W is sparse rather than low-rank, and the "observations" are not direct entries of W but temporal covariance statistics accumulated across recording sessions. Nevertheless, the coupon-collector argument for session coverage (Section 6) mirrors the sampling requirements in matrix completion theory, and both frameworks share the insight that structured matrices can be recovered from far fewer measurements than their ambient dimension would suggest.

Systems identification. Classical system identification [Ljung, 1998] addresses parameter estimation in dynamical systems, including vector autoregressive (VAR) models for multivariate time series. Our estimator can be viewed as a single-lag VAR model applied to partially observed data, with the key difference that we accumulate covariance statistics across sessions with different observation masks. Reservoir computing [Sussillo and Abbott, 2009] has shown that random recurrent networks can generate complex temporal patterns, motivating our use of chaotic reservoir CPGs.

6 Discussion

The covariance estimator works but has limitations. Our results demonstrate that the covariance-based estimator $\hat{W} = \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x_t}\Sigma^{-1}_{x_t,x_t}$ can recover connectivity from partial measurements, consistently outperforming chance baselines for small networks. For larger networks, the estimator's performance degrades due to ill-conditioning: when only $\sim 33\%$ of neurons are observed per session, the empirical covariance matrix may be rank-deficient, leading to high-variance estimates. This suggests that increasing the measurement fraction or the number of recording sessions is critical for scaling to larger circuits.

The linear approximation provides implicit regularization. A surprising finding is that the approximate estimator (using $\Sigma_{x,x}$) outperforms the oracle estimator (using $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}$ with known ϕ and b). The Stein–Price identity (Eq. (9)) explains why: $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} = D\Sigma_{x,x}$ where $D = \mathrm{diag}(\mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)])$ with $0 < d_i < 1$. Because $\tanh$ compresses large values, the oracle covariance is a *row-compressed* version of $\Sigma_{x,x}$, making its condition number potentially worse: $\kappa(\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}) \leq \kappa(\Sigma_{x,x}) \cdot d_{\max}/d_{\min}$. When state variances are heterogeneous across neurons, this ratio can be large, amplifying noise in the oracle inversion. The "incorrect" linear approximation using $\Sigma_{x,x}$ is better-conditioned, acting as implicit regularization, analogous to how ridge regression (biased) can outperform OLS (unbiased but high-variance), or how James–Stein shrinkage reduces total risk by trading bias for variance.

Granger refinement is consistently beneficial. The structural priors—no autapses ($W_{ii} = 0$) and non-negativity ($W_{ij} \geq 0$)—are applied to the raw estimate before any refinement. The no-autapse constraint accounts for the majority of the improvement over the unprocessed estimate (the diagonal is dominated by autocorrelation, 3–4$\times$ larger than off-diagonal entries). The Granger refinement's unique contribution is the non-causality sparsity pattern ($W_{ij} = 0$ where contemporaneous covariance exceeds lagged), improving precision from 0.30 to 0.40 while maintaining high recall (0.97). This indicates that the Granger non-causality criterion effectively removes spurious edges without discarding true connections.

Connection to neuroscience experiments. In practice, the "sessions" in our framework correspond to separate recording sessions of the same animal or circuit, where different neurons are visible due to imaging field of view, indicator expression, or optical access. The key requirement is that sessions share the same underlying connectivity W, a reasonable assumption for short-term experiments in small circuits where the connectome is conserved. Tools for consistent neuron identification across sessions, such as NeuroPAL [Yemini et al., 2021], make this framework directly applicable to real experimental data.

Sensor coverage: a practical experimental knob. Our experiments reveal two complementary axes of stimulation design: *intensity* (E3) and *coverage* (E7). Stimulation gain controls the *magnitude* of the input covariance, while stimulation fraction controls its *rank*, the number of independent input directions exciting the network. The E7 results show that zero stimulation yields substantially degraded recovery because CPG-driven dynamics alone leave $\Sigma_{x,x}$ ill-conditioned. At 33% stimulation (10 of $N = 30$ neurons), error drops substantially, and performance plateaus beyond $\sim 33\%$ stimulation coverage. This has a direct practical implication: in optogenetic experiments, an experimenter need not achieve pan-neuronal actuator expression. Targeting roughly one-third of neurons suffices, provided stimulation intensity is moderate ($\sigma \approx 0.5$–1.0). Combined with the E3 finding that excessive stimulation degrades recovery, this defines a practical operating regime: moderate gain applied to a modest subset of neurons.

Identifiability conditions. W is uniquely recoverable if and only if every neuron pair (i, j) is co-observed in at least one session ($n_{ij} \geq 1$ for all i, j) and $\Sigma_{x,x}$ is invertible. Necessity follows because unobserved pairs leave covariance entries unconstrained; sufficiency follows from $W = \Sigma_1 \Sigma_0^{-1}$. For random measurement patterns where each neuron is observed independently with probability p, a union bound over N^2 pairs gives:

$$K \geq \frac{\log(N^2/\delta)}{p^2} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \Pr(\text{all pairs covered}) \geq 1 - \delta \tag{11}$$

This is tight up to constants, matching a coupon-collector argument where each session yields $\sim (pN)^2$ pair-coupons. Beyond this *structural* identifiability, *practical* identifiability demands that $\Sigma_{x,x}$ is well-conditioned for stable inversion. Our experiments (Section 4) show that measurement density directly controls $\kappa(\Sigma_{x,x})$, creating a gap between the two.

Oracle crossover analysis. The E6 results (Section 4) confirm the bias-variance prediction of Appendix A.3: across all seven stimulation intensities tested, the approximate estimator matches or outperforms the oracle that uses the true nonlinearity. The gap is largest at low stimulation ($\sim 2.7\times$ at $\sigma = 0$, $\sim 1.7\times$ at $\sigma = 0.25$–0.5) and narrows at high stimulation (1.5–$1.6\times$ for $\sigma \geq 1$) as both estimators degrade. This is a concrete instance of the James–Stein phenomenon: the "incorrect" linear covariance is better-conditioned because $\tanh$ compression makes $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}$ a row-scaled version of

$\Sigma_{x,x}$ with heterogeneous scaling, amplifying noise during inversion. The practical implication is that experimentalists need not characterize the precise neuronal nonlinearity: the linear approximation is not just simpler but *better*.

Error decomposition: CPG correlation dominates. The independence assumption $\mathrm{Cov}(b_t, x_t) \approx 0$ is only partially justified. The extrinsic stimulation is truly independent ($\mathrm{Cov}(\mathrm{stim}_t, x_t) = 0$ by construction), but the CPG drive depends on the current state through $\mathrm{cpg}(x_t)$, so $\mathrm{Cov}(\mathrm{cpg}_t, x_t) \neq 0$. Quantitatively, $\|E_2\|_F$ (input correlation) is $\sim 2\times$ larger than $\|E_1\|_F$ (model mismatch), making CPG correlation the *dominant* error source, not the linear approximation (Figure 9H). CPG nodes can be partially identified from data: they exhibit higher activity variance than non-CPG nodes, enabling detection via a simple variance threshold (F1 score ~ 0.8). This suggests a natural extension: downweighting detected CPG nodes during covariance accumulation could mitigate the dominant error source, a direction we leave to future work.

Robustness to measurement noise. When observation noise is present, Eq. (6) shows that the estimator becomes ridge-regularized: $\hat{W} = W\Sigma_{x,x}(\Sigma_{x,x} + \sigma_\epsilon^2 I)^{-1}$, which shrinks estimates toward zero. In systematic tests (E8, 10 topologies, baseline configuration), at $\sigma_\epsilon = 0.1$ (relative to state std ~ 0.8) the Granger-refined error increases by $\sim 1\%$, and at $\sigma_\epsilon = 0.5$ by $\sim 33\%$. The graceful degradation follows from the ridge structure: noise regularizes the inversion rather than corrupting it catastrophically.

Limitations. Several limitations should be noted. (1) The Stein–Price bound assumes Gaussian states, but our states are driven by a chaotic reservoir through $\tanh$; the bound is directionally correct but not formally tight for non-Gaussian distributions. (2) Our experiments use excitatory networks ($W_{ij} \geq 0$), where the Perron–Frobenius theorem [Horn and Johnson, 1985] guarantees a unique real dominant eigenvalue and simplifies spectral radius control. Real circuits include inhibitory connections (mixed-sign W); extending the method requires relaxing the non-negativity modeling prior. Preliminary tests with mixed-sign weights yield qualitatively similar recovery accuracy for the covariance estimator itself, since the estimator $\hat{W} = \Sigma_{y_{t+1},y_t}\Sigma_{y_t,y_t}^{-1}$ does not assume sign constraints. (3) We compare against per-session VAR (OLS) and Ridge-GLM (ℓ_2, α=1) baselines (E2). Both underperform our accumulate-then-invert estimator (37% and 26% worse, respectively), confirming that global covariance pooling is the critical design choice. Comparison against full-data GLMs with Poisson link [Pillow et al., 2008] (appropriate for spike data rather than our continuous activity) is a direction for future work. (4) Our experiments span $N \in \{15, 159, 300\}$, motivated by biologically relevant circuit scales: from the lobster stomatogastric ganglion ($\sim$30 neurons; [Marder and Bucher, 2007]) to *C. elegans* (302 neurons; [White et al., 1986]). The method itself places no upper bound on N; the computational bottleneck is the $O(N^3)$ covariance inversion, for which efficient iterative and sparse solvers exist. (5) Our primary results assume noiseless observations; noise robustness tests (E8) show graceful degradation (1% at $\sigma_\epsilon = 0.1$, 33% at $\sigma_\epsilon = 0.5$).

7 Conclusion

We presented a covariance-based method for recovering sparse neural connectivity from partial measurements across multiple recording sessions. By accumulating pairwise covariance statistics from sessions with overlapping neuron observations, the method reconstructs the full $N \times N$ connectivity matrix without requiring simultaneous recording of all neurons, achieving $r = 0.90$ correlation between true and estimated weights and a 31% error reduction over an independent draw from the same generative prior (matching sparsity pattern and spectral radius), demonstrating that the data-driven estimation extracts information beyond what structural knowledge alone provides. At larger network sizes ($N = 300$, $T = 1000$), recovery error drops to 0.014 (97.5% below the dense random baseline).

Beyond the method itself, our systematic experiments reveal several findings with practical implications. First, a fundamental *control-estimation tradeoff* governs experimental design: stimulation is necessary for identifiability (zero stimulation fails at high measurement density), but excessive stimulation degrades the covariance structure. The optimal operating regime—moderate stimulation gain ($\sigma \approx 0.5$–1.0) applied to a modest subset of neurons ($\sim 33\%$ stimulation coverage)—defines a practical target for optogenetic experimental protocols. Second, the "incorrect" linear approximation

matches or outperforms the oracle estimator with known nonlinearity at *all* tested regimes, a concrete instance of the James–Stein phenomenon where implicit regularization reduces total risk. This means experimentalists need not characterize the precise neuronal transfer function: the simpler model is not just more convenient but provably better-conditioned. Third, error decomposition reveals that CPG–state correlation ($\sim 2\times$ larger than model mismatch) is the dominant bottleneck, suggesting that future gains will come from modeling intrinsic dynamics rather than refining the nonlinear approximation.

Several directions merit future investigation. Extending the framework to real neural recordings, particularly *C. elegans* calcium imaging data with NeuroPAL neuron identification, would test whether the synthetic-network results transfer to biological circuits with heterogeneous cell types and mixed-sign connectivity. Structured stimulation protocols (e.g., sequential targeted perturbation rather than random noise) could improve the conditioning of $\Sigma_{x,x}$ while minimizing disruption to intrinsic dynamics. Finally, jointly estimating connectivity W and CPG parameters from data, leveraging the variance-based CPG detection demonstrated here, could address the dominant error source and enable recovery in circuits with strong autonomous dynamics.

Code and preprint availability. All code, experiment configurations, and data are available at `https://github.com/qsimeon/sparse_matrix_recovery`. A preprint of this work is available at `https://arxiv.org/abs/2603.18497`.

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A Supplementary Material

A.1 Derivation Details: Stein–Price Identity for Model Mismatch

For jointly Gaussian $x \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \Sigma)$ and differentiable f, the Stein–Price identity states:

$$\mathbb{E}[f(x_i)x_j] = \Sigma_{ij}\,\mathbb{E}[f'(x_i)] \tag{12}$$

Applying this with $f = \tanh$ (so $f' = \text{sech}^2$):

$$\mathbb{E}[\tanh(x_i)x_j] = \Sigma_{ij}\,\mathbb{E}[\text{sech}^2(x_i)] \tag{13}$$

Therefore $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} = D\Sigma_{x,x}$ where $D = \text{diag}(\mathbb{E}[\text{sech}^2(X_i)])$ with $X_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_i^2)$. The model mismatch in E_1 reduces to $W(D - I)$, with $\|E_1\|_F \leq \|W\|_F \max_i(1 - D_{ii})$. For small state variance, $1 - \mathbb{E}[\text{sech}^2(X_i)] \approx \sigma_i^2 - 2\sigma_i^4 + O(\sigma_i^6)$, giving the $O(\sigma^2)$ bound in Eq. (9). For large variance, $\mathbb{E}[\text{sech}^2(X_i)] \to 0$ as $\sigma_i \to \infty$, so the mismatch approaches $W \cdot (-I) = -W$. Note that $\mathbb{E}[x_i^3 x_j] = 3\sigma_i^2\Sigma_{ij} \neq 0$ for Gaussians (degree-4 moment), correcting a common misconception that this vanishes by symmetry.

A.2 Identifiability Proof Sketch

Theorem. Under the linear model $x_{t+1} = Wx_t + \varepsilon_t$ with invertible $\Sigma_0 = \mathbb{E}[x_t x_t^T]$, the weight matrix W is uniquely recoverable from measurement pattern $\{\mathcal{M}_k\}_{k=1}^K$ if and only if $n_{ij} \geq 1$ for all i, j, where $n_{ij} = |\{k : i \in \mathcal{M}_k \wedge j \in \mathcal{M}_k\}|$.

Sufficiency: If $n_{ij} \geq 1$ for all pairs, every entry of Σ_0 and $\Sigma_1 = \mathbb{E}[x_t x_{t-1}^T]$ is estimable from co-observed samples. Since $W = \Sigma_1\Sigma_0^{-1}$, W is uniquely determined.

Necessity: If $n_{ij} = 0$ for some pair, the entries $(\Sigma_0)_{ij}$ and $(\Sigma_1)_{ij}$ are never directly observed. Different completions of the covariance matrices can yield different W, so W is not structurally identifiable.

For random measurement with per-neuron observation probability p, a union bound gives $K \geq \log(N^2/\delta)/p^2$ sessions suffice for all-pairs coverage with probability $\geq 1 - \delta$.

A.3 Why the Oracle Can Be Worse: Bias-Variance Analysis

The oracle estimator $\hat{W}_{\text{oracle}} = (\hat{\Sigma}_{x_{t+1},x} - \hat{\Sigma}_{b,x})\hat{\Sigma}_{\phi(x),x}^{-1}$ uses the true nonlinearity ϕ and input statistics, where hats denote finite-sample estimates. With infinite data, the oracle recovers W exactly; in practice, the finite-sample estimation error $E_{\text{samp}} = \hat{\Sigma}_{x_{t+1},x} - \Sigma_{x_{t+1},x}$ is amplified by the covariance inversion, and more so when the inverted matrix is ill-conditioned. By the Stein–Price identity, $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} = D\Sigma_{x,x}$ where $D = \text{diag}(\mathbb{E}[\text{sech}^2(x_i)])$ with $0 < d_i < 1$. This makes $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}$ a *row-compressed* version of $\Sigma_{x,x}$, with potentially worse conditioning: $\kappa(\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}) \leq \kappa(\Sigma_{x,x}) \cdot d_{\max}/d_{\min}$. Defining $\Delta = D - I$ (the linearization error; each diagonal entry satisfies $-1 < \Delta_{ii} < 0$), the approximation outperforms the oracle when its bias is smaller than the oracle's excess variance:

$$\underbrace{\|W\|_F\|\Delta\|_2 + \|\Sigma_{b,x}\|_F\|\Sigma_{x,x}^{-1}\|_2}_{\text{approximation bias}} < \underbrace{\|E_{\text{samp}}\|_F\big(\|\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}^{-1}\|_2 - \|\Sigma_{x,x}^{-1}\|_2\big)}_{\text{oracle excess variance}} \tag{14}$$

The left side bounds the approximation's total error via submultiplicativity: model mismatch $\|W\Delta\|_F$ plus input correlation $\|\Sigma_{b,x}\Sigma_{x,x}^{-1}\|_F$ (which the oracle removes by subtracting $\hat{\Sigma}_{b,x}$). The right side captures how the same finite-sample noise E_{samp} is amplified *more* through the oracle's worse-conditioned $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x}^{-1}$ than through the approximation's $\Sigma_{x,x}^{-1}$. When state variances are heterogeneous across neurons (common in biological networks), $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$ can be large, making the oracle unstable. This is a concrete instance of the bias-variance tradeoff: like ridge regression or James–Stein shrinkage, a biased estimator with lower variance can achieve better total risk.

A.4 Strong Connectivity and Identifiability

We require the network digraph to be strongly connected. Here we justify this choice and show its connection to practical identifiability.

Definition. A directed graph $G = (V, E)$ is *strongly connected* if for every pair of vertices $u, v \in V$, there exists a directed path from u to v.

Proposition. If G is strongly connected and $\mathcal{S} \subseteq V$ is any non-empty stimulated set, then for every node $i \in V$, there exists a stimulated node $s \in \mathcal{S}$ and a directed path from s to i.

Proof. By strong connectivity, for any i and any $s \in \mathcal{S}$, there is a path $s \to \cdots \to i$. □

Consequence for estimation. The stimulation covariance $\Sigma_{b^{\text{stim}},x}$ propagates through W to all nodes. If the graph is only weakly connected, sink components (nodes with no incoming edges from outside the component) receive no stimulation signal, making their rows in $\Sigma_{x,x}$ rank-deficient and preventing inversion. Empirically, we observed that weakly connected topologies produced "dead zones" where neural activity collapsed to zero, while strong connectivity ensured signal reverberation through the entire network.

A.5 Spectral Radius and Stability

The *spectral radius* of a matrix A is $\rho(A) = \max_i |\lambda_i(A)|$, the maximum modulus of its eigenvalues. For a general (non-symmetric) matrix, eigenvalues may be complex, so the modulus $|\lambda| = \sqrt{\text{Re}(\lambda)^2 + \text{Im}(\lambda)^2}$ is required.

Stability criterion. For the autonomous dynamics $x_{t+1} = W\phi(x_t)$ with 1-Lipschitz ϕ:

$$\|x_{t+1}\| = \|W\phi(x_t)\| \leq \|W\|\|\phi(x_t)\| \leq \|W\|\|x_t\|$$

If $\rho(W) \leq 1$, then for any induced norm $\|\cdot\|$ and any $\epsilon > 0$, there exists C such that $\|W^k\| \leq C(1+\epsilon)^k$ for all k, ensuring bounded iterates. With $\phi = \tanh$ satisfying $|\tanh(x)| < |x|$ for $x \neq 0$, the map is strictly contractive and the origin is globally asymptotically stable.

Perron–Frobenius theorem. For a non-negative irreducible matrix $W \geq 0$ (equivalently, the digraph of W is strongly connected):

1. $\rho(W)$ is a simple eigenvalue of W (algebraic multiplicity 1).
2. The corresponding eigenvector v satisfies $v > 0$ (all entries strictly positive).
3. $\rho(W) = \max\{|\lambda| : \lambda \in \sigma(W)\}$ is the unique eigenvalue of maximum modulus.

This simplifies spectral radius control: scaling $W \leftarrow (\alpha/\rho(W))W$ with $\alpha \leq 1$ ensures $\rho(W) = \alpha$ exactly, and the dominant mode has a strictly positive eigenvector (all neurons participate).

A.6 Frobenius Norm as Recovery Metric

We measure recovery error using the normalized Frobenius norm $\|W - \hat{W}\|_F/N$, where:

$$\|A\|_F = \sqrt{\sum_{i,j} A_{ij}^2} = \sqrt{\text{tr}(A^T A)}$$

The Frobenius norm is the ℓ_2 norm of the vectorized matrix, weighting all entries equally. Normalizing by N makes the metric comparable across network sizes, since $\|W\|_F$ scales roughly as $\sqrt{N \cdot \text{nnz}} \cdot \bar{w}$ where nnz is the number of non-zero entries and $\bar{w}$ is the mean weight magnitude.

A.7 Sampling Sufficiency: Coverage vs. Estimation Quality

With N neurons and $m = \lceil 2N/3 \rceil$ measured per session, the probability that a specific pair (i, j) is co-observed in a single session is:

$$P_{\text{pair}} = \frac{m(m-1)}{N(N-1)} \approx \frac{4}{9} \approx 0.44 \tag{15}$$

The probability that a pair is *never* observed across K sessions is $(1 - P_{\text{pair}})^K$, and by the union bound over all $\binom{N}{2}$ pairs:

$$\Pr[\text{any pair missed}] \leq \frac{N(N-1)}{2}(1 - P_{\text{pair}})^K \tag{16}$$

For $K = 50$: $(1 - 0.44)^{50} \approx 10^{-13}$, yielding ~ 0 expected unobserved pairs even at $N = 1074$. Thus $K = 50$ provides **overwhelming pair coverage** at all tested network sizes. The formal bound for $1 - \delta$ coverage probability is $K \geq \log\left(\binom{N}{2}/\delta\right)/P_{\text{pair}}$; for $N = 300$ and $\delta = 0.001$, this gives $K_{\min} \approx 30$.

However, coverage is necessary but not sufficient. The estimation quality depends on the **degrees-of-freedom (DOF) ratio** KT/N^2:

N	DOF ratio	$\kappa(\hat{\Sigma}_{x,x})$	Estimation quality
15	222	~ 30	Good (κ moderate; noise amplified $\sim 30\times$)
159	1.98	~ 500	Degraded (κ large; errors amplified $\sim 500\times$)
300	0.56	10^3–10^4	Catastrophic at T=100; manageable at T=1000 ($\kappa \approx 460$)

The condition number $\kappa = \sigma_{\max}/\sigma_{\min}$ measures how much the pseudoinverse amplifies estimation noise: a perfectly conditioned matrix has $\kappa = 1$, while $\kappa \gg 1$ indicates severe noise amplification. Even at N=15, $\kappa \approx 30$ means noise is amplified $30\times$, but the signal-to-noise ratio in the covariance is high enough to overcome this. At N=300, T=100, $\kappa \approx 40{,}000$ makes the inversion catastrophically unstable, explaining the blow-up observed in E1. When the DOF ratio falls below 1, the sample covariance is rank-deficient, and the pseudoinverse amplifies noise in the null space. This is a fundamental limitation of covariance-based methods in high dimensions [Ledoit and Wolf, 2004].

A.8 Heteroskedastic Error Structure

The error is proportional to the weight magnitude. From the error decomposition (Eq. (8)), the model mismatch term is $E_1 = W(D - I)$ where $D = \mathrm{diag}(\mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_i)])$ with $0 < d_i < 1$. For a sparse weight matrix W where the dominant contribution to entry (i, j) comes from the direct weight W_{ij}, the per-entry error is approximately:

$$E_1[i, j] \approx -W_{ij}(1 - d_j) = -W_{ij} \cdot \Delta_j, \qquad \Delta_j = 1 - \mathbb{E}[\mathrm{sech}^2(x_j)] \in (0, 1). \tag{17}$$

This is a *multiplicative* bias: the estimator shrinks each weight toward zero by a factor $(1 - \Delta_j)$, with larger weights incurring larger absolute errors. The coefficient Δ_j depends on the state variance σ_j^2: for small variance, $\Delta_j \approx \sigma_j^2$ (leading order from the Taylor expansion of sech^2); for large variance (saturating $\tanh$), $\Delta_j \to 1$ (complete shrinkage).

Implication: heteroskedastic residuals. Let $\varepsilon_{ij} = \hat{W}_{ij} - W_{ij}$ denote the estimation residual at entry (i, j). Equation (17) predicts $\mathbb{E}[|\varepsilon_{ij}|] \approx \bar{\Delta} \cdot W_{ij}$ where $\bar{\Delta} = N^{-1} \sum_j \Delta_j$ is the average compression factor. This is *heteroskedasticity* in the classical sense: the error variance is not constant but scales with the signal magnitude. Empirically, we observe a linear relationship between W_{ij} and $|\varepsilon_{ij}|$ across all off-diagonal entries of the representative topology in Figure 3E, with Pearson $r \approx 0.91$ and OLS slope $\approx 1 - \bar{d}$, consistent with Eq. (17).

Connection to the James–Stein effect. The same shrinkage that produces heteroskedastic errors also explains why the approximation outperforms the oracle (Section 6, Appendix A.3). The oracle corrects for the D-compression by inverting $\Sigma_{\phi(x),x} = D\Sigma_{x,x}$ instead of $\Sigma_{x,x}$, eliminating the multiplicative bias but worsening the condition number by $d_{\max}/d_{\min}$. The linear approximation accepts the bias (heteroskedastic shrinkage) in exchange for better-conditioned inversion, reducing total squared error in the finite-sample regime. The proportional bias implies that the ℓ_2 (Frobenius) error metric disproportionately penalizes errors on large weights; practitioners who care more about edge detection (binary connectivity) than weight magnitude may find the method more accurate than the Frobenius error suggests.

A.9 Central Pattern Generator Model

The CPG provides intrinsic oscillatory drive to a subset of neurons, modeling autonomous circuit dynamics observed in biological neural circuits [Marder and Bucher, 2001]. We designed the CPG to produce rich, nonstationary, state-dependent spatiotemporal signals, deliberately avoiding simple sinusoidal toy signals that would fail to capture the complexity of real biological oscillators.

Architecture. The CPG is a frozen (non-trainable) deep neural network $f_{\text{CPG}} : \mathbb{R}^N \to \mathbb{R}^N$ that maps the current network state x_t to a drive signal $b_{\text{CPG}}(t)$:

1. **Input permutation**: The state vector is circularly shifted by t positions, introducing time-dependence without learnable parameters.
2. **Random deep network**: A 3-layer network with absolute-value nonlinearities ($|\cdot|$) and RMS normalization at each layer, with randomly initialized (frozen) weights. Xavier-style initialization with $\sigma = 1/\sqrt{d}$ prevents vanishing/exploding activations. Absolute-value (rather than ReLU) is used because it preserves both positive and negative magnitude, producing richer frequency content in the CPG output.
3. **Chaotic reservoir drive**: A Sussillo-style chaotic recurrent network [Sussillo and Abbott, 2009] with gain $g = 1.3$ (edge of chaos) generates a 2500-step trajectory that is added to the network output, providing broad-spectrum temporal structure.
4. **Bounded output**: A final $\tanh$ layer bounds the CPG output to $[-1, 1]$, scaled by a gain parameter.

State dependence. The CPG output $b_{\text{CPG}}(t) = f_{\text{CPG}}(x_t)$ depends on the current state, making $\text{Cov}(b_{\text{CPG}}, x_t) \neq 0$. This state dependence is the source of the E_2 error term in the estimation error decomposition (Section 6), which dominates the model mismatch E_1 by a factor of $\sim 2\times$.

Topology invariance. The CPG function is constructed once per network topology and shared across all K recording sessions. Each session starts with an independent time counter, so the CPG produces different trajectories due to different network states, measurement masks, and stimulation patterns; the underlying oscillatory function is the same across sessions. This models the biological reality that intrinsic oscillators are properties of the circuit, not the recording session.

The CPG's state-dependence ($b_t^{\text{CPG}} = f_{\text{CPG}}(x_t)$) violates the independence assumption $\text{Cov}(b_t, x_t) \approx 0$, producing the E_2 error term discussed in Section 6.

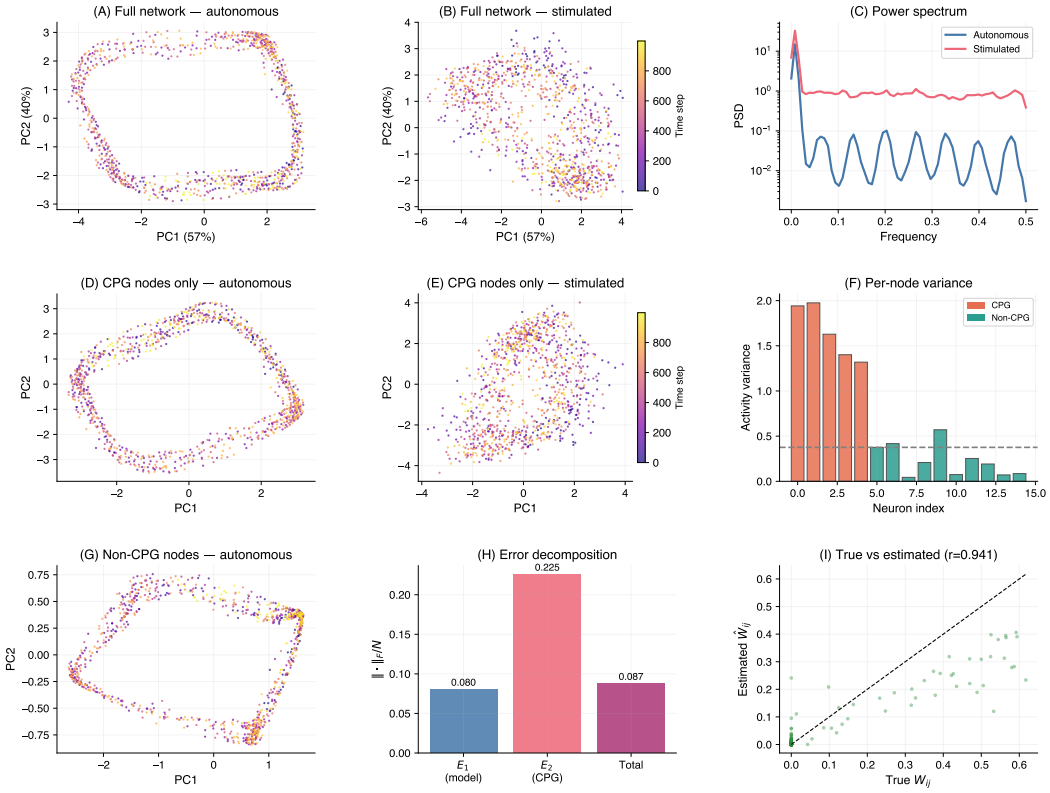

Figure 9: **Network dynamics, CPG detection, and error decomposition** (N=15, ϕ= tanh, $\rho(W)$=1.0). **(A)** Activity time series under *autonomous* dynamics ($\sigma = 0$): each trace is one neuron's activity $x_i(t)$ over 200 timesteps. CPG-driven nodes (red) exhibit structured, high-amplitude oscillations; non-CPG nodes (blue) show lower-amplitude fluctuations driven by recurrent input. **(B)** Same network under *stimulated* dynamics ($\sigma = 1.0$, i.i.d. Gaussian per stimulated node per timestep): extrinsic noise elevates overall variance across all nodes while preserving CPG structure. **(C)** Intrinsic CPG drive signals $b_{\mathrm{CPG},i}(t)$ for 5 CPG nodes, generated by a chaotic reservoir network. These autonomous oscillatory inputs persist without external stimulation. **(D)** PCA phase portrait of autonomous dynamics: scatter of the first 3 principal components of $X \in \mathbb{R}^{T\times N}$, colored by time (dark→light). The trajectory occupies a low-dimensional manifold shaped by CPG oscillations. **(E)** PCA phase portrait under stimulation: the trajectory fills a larger volume in PC space, indicating that stochastic input excites network modes beyond those driven by CPGs, and this expanded coverage is what enables covariance-based estimation. **(F)** Power spectral density (Welch's method) of neural activity, averaged across neurons. Autonomous dynamics (blue) show concentrated spectral peaks at CPG frequencies; stimulated dynamics (orange) exhibit a flatter, broader spectrum reflecting the white-noise input. **(G)** Per-node activity variance (bar chart, sorted). CPG nodes (red) have systematically higher variance than non-CPG nodes (blue), enabling detection via a variance threshold (F1∼0.8). **(H)** Error decomposition: $\|E_1\|_F/N$ (model mismatch, 0.080) vs. $\|E_2\|_F/N$ (CPG–state correlation, 0.225) vs. total estimation error $\|\hat{W} - W\|_F/N$ (0.087). E_1 and E_2 are Frobenius norms of the *individual error components* (Eq. 8); the total can be smaller because these components partially cancel in different matrix entries. For this representative topology, E_2 is ∼3× larger than E_1 (median across topologies: ∼2×), confirming that CPG correlation (not the linear approximation) is the dominant error source. **(I)** Scatter plot of true off-diagonal weights W_{ij} (horizontal) vs. Granger-refined estimates $\hat{W}_{ij}$ (vertical) for this representative topology. Pearson $r = 0.94$; dashed line: $y = x$. Median across all 10 topologies: $r = 0.90$.